

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Book I: The Covenant

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CHAPTER 1: THE PREDATOR

The courtroom smelled of floor wax, old wood, and the specific, acrid sweat of a man who knows he is about to lose everything.

Erin Bruner stood at the defense table, her hand resting lightly on the mahogany. She didn't look at the jury. Not yet. She looked at the prosecutor, a man named Miller who was currently sweating through his cheap polyester suit. Miller was droning on about "justice" and "societal debt," words that meant nothing in this room. In this room, there was only one currency: Doubt.

And Erin was rich.

She glanced at her client, James Van Hopper. He was a small man with eyes like dead fish—flat, black, and devoid of anything resembling a soul. He was guilty. Erin knew it. Karl Gunderson, the senior partner watching from the gallery, knew it. Even the bailiff, who was currently fighting a losing battle against sleep, knew it. Van Hopper had killed his wife. He had strangled her with a telephone cord in a fit of rage because she burned the roast.

But "knowing" and "proving" were two different countries, and Erin held the passport between them.

"Ms. Bruner?" Judge Holloway asked. "Your closing?"

Erin moved. She didn't walk; she glided. It was a practiced movement, designed to draw every eye in the room. She wore a tailored grey suit—Armani, bought with the bonus from the Carruthers acquittal—that was professional enough to command respect but feminine enough to disarm the older men on the jury.

"Ladies and gentlemen," Erin began. Her voice was low, forcing the jurors to lean in. It was a trick she learned in her first year. *Make them come to you.* "Mr. Miller talks about justice. He talks about the tragedy of Mrs. Van Hopper's death. And it is a tragedy."

She paused, letting the silence stretch until it was almost uncomfortable.

"But we are not here to mourn. We are here to determine facts. And the fact is, the timeline doesn't fit."

She walked to the timeline exhibit. A simple piece of foam board that was about to save a murderer.

"The State claims Mr. Van Hopper was home at 6:00 PM. But Mrs. Higgins, the neighbor... the State's own witness... testified she saw his car leaving at 5:45. Fifteen minutes." Erin turned to the jury, locking eyes with Juror Number 4, a schoolteacher who had been nodding along with Miller earlier. "Fifteen minutes. That is the difference between a murderer and a grieving husband. Can you be sure? Can you look at this man and say, with absolute certainty, that Mrs. Higgins—a woman who admitted she wasn't wearing her glasses—saw what she claims she saw?"

She saw the doubt bloom in Juror 4's eyes. It was a physical thing, a subtle shift in posture, a slight furrowing of the brow.

Got you, Erin thought.

"If you have even a shadow of a doubt," Erin whispered, "you must acquit. That is the law. That is the promise we make to every citizen. Even the ones we don't like."

She sat down.

Van Hopper leaned over. "That was good," he whispered. His breath smelled of mints and rot.

"Don't talk to me," Erin said, her voice devoid of warmth. "Look at the table. Look sad."

The verdict came back two hours later.

Not Guilty.

As the words were read, Erin didn't smile. She didn't pump her fist. She simply nodded, a mask of professional solemnity. But inside, the adrenaline hit her like a drug. It was better than sex. It was better than love. It was the pure, uncut high of winning.

She packed her briefcase, ignoring Van Hopper's outstretched hand.

"You're a wizard, Erin," he said.

"I'm a lawyer, James," she said, snapping the locks shut. "There's a difference. Pay the bill."

She walked out of the courtroom, the heels of her shoes clicking a rhythm on the marble floor.

Click-clack. Click-clack. The sound of a predator leaving the kill site.

CHAPTER 2: THE VICTORY LAP

The bar was called "The Gavel," because lawyers were nothing if not uncreative with their watering holes. It was dark, smoky, and loud. The air was thick with the smell of expensive scotch, cheap beer, and ambition.

The firm had rented out the back room. It was a sea of suits.

"To Erin!"

The toast came from everywhere. Glasses clinked.

Erin raised her vodka tonic. She took a sip. It was cold, sharp, and clean. It washed away the taste of Van Hopper's breath.

"You really pulled that one out of the fire," Ray said. Ray was a junior associate who looked at Erin with a mix of terrified awe and lust. "I thought the neighbor's testimony was going to sink us."

"The neighbor was senile, Ray," Erin said, leaning against the bar. "You just had to remind the jury that she watches *Soap Operas* all afternoon. Reality blurs."

Ray laughed, but it was a nervous sound. "Still. Van Hopper... he did it, right?"

Erin looked at him. The question hung in the air, heavy and wet.

"Ray," she said, her voice dropping to that dangerous register she used in court. "Did the jury say he did it?"

"No."

"Then he didn't do it."

"But... moral truth?"

"Moral truth is for priests and poets. We deal in legal truth. And legal truth is a construct. It's a building we build, brick by brick, out of evidence and procedure. If the building stands, the client walks."

She turned away, dismissing him. She scanned the room.

Success.

It looked like this. Tailored suits, laughter, the promise of bonuses.

So why did she feel like she was standing at the bottom of a deep well?

She looked at her reflection in the mirror behind the bar.

Who are you?

The woman in the mirror didn't answer. She just looked tired.

The adrenaline was fading, leaving behind the crash. The emptiness.

She had saved a monster today. And she would get a raise for it.

Karl Gunderson appeared at her elbow.

"You're not celebrating," he observed.

"I am. Internally."

"Save it," Karl said. "I need you in my office tomorrow morning. Early."

"Good news?"

Karl smiled. It was the smile of a shark who just smelled blood in the water.

"Big news. The Archdiocese."

"Church business? I thought they had their own lawyers."

"Not for this. This is... special." Karl swirled his scotch. "Go home, Erin. Get some sleep. You're going to need it."

CHAPTER 3: THE HANGOVER

Erin lived in a condo that cost more than her parents' house and looked like it had been decorated by a robot. Chrome, glass, black leather. It was beautiful. It was sterile. It was cold.

She woke up at 6:00 AM, her head throbbing a dull, rhythmic beat behind her eyes. *Thump. Thump. Thump.*

She sat up, the sheets pooling around her waist.

The room was silent.

Too silent.

She got out of bed, her feet sinking into the deep pile carpet. She walked to the kitchen, the hum of the refrigerator the only sound in the world.

She started the coffee maker. *Gurgle. Hiss.*

While it brewed, she fed Jasper.

The Persian cat looked at her with disdain, waiting for the wet food.

"Here," she muttered, spooning the glop into his bowl. "Don't say I never did anything for you."

She took her coffee to the window. The city was waking up below. Grey light filtered through the smog.

It was raining again.

She pressed her forehead against the cold glass.

Van Hopper was out there somewhere. waking up in his own bed. Maybe making coffee. Maybe looking at the empty spot where his wife used to be.

Did he feel guilt?

Probably not. Men like that didn't feel guilt. They felt entitlement.

And she had put him back on the street.

She took a sip of coffee. It tasted burnt.

Stop it, she told herself. *It's the job. Everyone deserves a defense.*

But the thought tasted like ash.

She turned back to the room.

Jasper was standing in the hallway.

He wasn't eating.

He was staring at the front door.

"Jasper?"

The cat didn't move. His tail twitched.

Erin looked at the door. It was locked. The deadbolt was thrown.

But for a second—just a fraction of a second—she thought she saw the handle turn.

She blinked.

The handle was still.

"You need to get a grip, Bruner," she whispered. "You're seeing things."

She walked to the bathroom to shower. The hot water hit her skin, scalding away the night. She scrubbed hard, using the loofah until her skin was pink and raw. Trying to scrub off the courtroom. Scrub off Van Hopper.

She stepped out, wrapping a towel around her hair.

She wiped the steam off the mirror.

For a moment, her reflection looked... distorted.

Her eyes looked too dark. Her mouth looked too wide.

She blinked again.

Just the steam. Just the condensation.

But a shiver ran down her spine, cold and sharp, like an ice cube dropped down her back.

She dressed quickly.

She wanted to get out of the apartment.

It felt... crowded today.

Even though she was the only one there.

CHAPTER 4: THE SUMMIT

Karl Gunderson's office was a shrine to his own ego. It was a corner office, naturally, with floor-to-ceiling windows that offered a panoramic view of the city he helped rule. The furniture was leather, the desk was glass, and the art on the walls was abstract and expensive—splashes of red and black that looked like violent crime scenes framed in gold.

Erin walked in at 8:00 AM sharp. She was wearing her armor: a black suit, white blouse, and a diamond pendant that caught the morning light.

Karl was standing by the window, looking down at the ants below.

"Erin," he said, not turning around. "Coffee?"

"Black."

He poured a cup from the silver carafe on his sidebar and handed it to her.

"The Archdiocese is a very old, very wealthy client," Karl began, sitting on the edge of his desk. "They usually handle their own messes. But this one... this one has teeth."

"You mentioned a negligent homicide," Erin said, taking a seat. "Father Richard Moore."

"Yes. The DA is throwing the book at him. And not just any DA. Ethan Thomas."

Erin paused, the cup halfway to her lips. "Thomas? I thought he was on the Mayor's task force."

"He requested this case personally. He sees it as a crusade. He's a devout Methodist, you know. He thinks the Catholic Church is a breeding ground for superstition and abuse. He wants to make Moore the face of everything wrong with organized religion."

"So it's political."

"It's theatrical," Karl corrected. "Thomas wants a show trial. He wants to drag the Middle Ages into the 20th century and put it on the stand. He wants to prove that demons don't exist, and that anyone who believes in them is mentally ill and dangerous."

Erin set her cup down. "And you want me to defend the Middle Ages?"

"I want you to defend the *Institution*," Karl said, his voice hardening. "The Church is terrified. If Moore is convicted, it opens the floodgates. Civil suits. Liability. The PR nightmare alone could bankrupt the diocese. They need a firewall."

"And I'm the firewall."

"You're the best trial lawyer I have. You can sell ice to Eskimos. You can sell doubt to a jury that wants blood."

Karl leaned forward. "If you win this, Erin... the Senior Partnership is yours. Your name on the door. A corner office. The whole package."

Erin looked at him. The partnership. The Golden Fleece she had been chasing for ten years.

"And if I lose?"

Karl smiled. It didn't reach his eyes.

"Then you'll always be the very talented associate who *almost* made it."

The threat hung in the air, perfumed and polite.

"I'll take the case," Erin said.

"Good. Moore is being held at County. Go see him. But be warned... he's a bit intense."

CHAPTER 5: THE DESCENT

The drive to the County Jail was a descent in every sense of the word. Erin drove her Mercedes from the gleaming canyons of the financial district down to the rusted, graffiti-stained arteries of the south side. The architecture changed from glass and steel to brick and barbed wire. The people changed from suits to jumpsuits.

She parked in the visitors' lot, checking her reflection in the rearview mirror. Perfect. Impenetrable.

She walked into the intake center. The smell hit her first.

It was a specific cocktail of odors: industrial pine cleaner, unwashed bodies, stale cigarette smoke, and fear. It was the smell of caged animals.

She checked her bag with the guard, a woman with tired eyes and a belt weighed down by keys and pepper spray.

"Attorney visit for Moore," Erin said.

"Block D. Solitary."

Solitary?

Erin walked through the metal detector. *Beep.*

"Underwire," she muttered.

The guard waved the wand. "Go ahead."

The corridors were long, echoey tunnels of concrete.

Clack. Clack. Clack.

Inmates watched her from the communal cells. Catcalls. Whistles.

"Hey, sweetness! You looking for a client?"

"I didn't do it, baby! Come talk to me!"

Erin didn't flinch. She stared straight ahead, her face a mask of indifference. She had walked these halls a hundred times. They were just noise.

Block D was quieter. It was where they kept the high-risk cases. The psychotics. The cop-killers.

And apparently, the priests.

The guard at the end of the hall unlocked the heavy steel door.

"He's in Interview Room 2. Watch yourself, counselor. He's been weird all night."

"Weird how?"

"Talking to himself. Or... not to himself." The guard shivered. "Just watch your back."

CHAPTER 6: THE SAINT IN HELL

Ghost Injection: Father Moore's Perspective.

The cell was six by eight. A stone coffin.

Richard Moore sat on the edge of the cot. His hands were clasped, his knuckles white.

He wasn't praying. Not exactly. He was holding the line.

The air in the cell was heavy. It felt viscous, like he was breathing underwater.

They were here.

Not in the flesh. Not like they were with Emily. But they were watching.

He could hear the scratching in the walls.

Scritch. Scritch.

It wasn't rats. Rats had a rhythm. This was chaotic. Spiteful.

"You failed her," the voice whispered.

It wasn't a sound. It was a thought inserted into his brain, cold and sharp as a needle.

"You let her die. You let her starve. You're not a priest. You're a murderer."

Moore closed his eyes tighter.

"Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me, a sinner."

"Mercy?" The voice laughed. It sounded like tearing metal. "There is no mercy. Only the Void. She is with us now, priest. We are feasting on her soul. She is screaming your name."

"Liar!" Moore whispered. "She is at peace. She is with the Mother."

"She is meat. Just like you."

The temperature in the cell dropped. Moore could see his breath puffing out in white clouds. Frost began to form on the metal toilet bowl.

A shadow detached itself from the corner. A darker darkness.

It loomed over him.

Moore didn't look up. He knew what it looked like. He had seen it in the barn. He had seen it in Emily's eyes.

"Look at me," the shadow commanded.

"I look only to the Cross."

"The Cross is wood. Wood rots. Flesh rots. Everything rots."

The door buzzed. A loud, jarring mechanical sound.

The shadow dissolved into the gloom. The temperature snapped back to the humid warmth of the jail.

"Moore!" the guard yelled. "Lawyer's here."

Moore stood up. His legs were shaky. He was exhausted. He hadn't slept in three days.

But he smoothed his cassock. He put on his collar.

He had a job to do.

He had to tell the story.

Not for himself.

For her.

He walked to the door, leaving the demons in the dark.

For now.

CHAPTER 7: FIRST CONTACT

The interview room was a box of cinderblocks painted a color that could only be described as "institutional despair green." There was a metal table bolted to the floor, two metal chairs, and a two-way mirror that everyone pretended wasn't there.

Erin sat on one side, her briefcase open, a yellow legal pad ready. She looked pristine, a diamond in a coal chute.

The door opened.

Father Moore walked in.

He wasn't what she expected.

In the photos, he looked younger. Cleaner. The man who sat down opposite her looked like he had been to war. His skin was grey, drawn tight over his cheekbones. His eyes were deep-set, dark, and burning with an intensity that made Erin instinctively want to look away. He smelled of stale incense and sweat.

He sat down. The chains on his wrists clinked against the table.

He didn't speak. He just looked at her.

Erin cleared her throat. Control. Establish dominance.

"Father Moore," she said, her voice brisk. "I'm Erin Bruner. The Archdiocese has retained me to represent you."

Moore looked at her suit, her pen, her pad. He smiled, but it was a sad, weary expression.

"You're very young," he said. His voice was rough, like gravel tumbling down a chute.

"I'm very expensive," Erin countered. "And I'm very good. Which is what you need, considering the District Attorney wants to put you in a cell for the rest of your life."

"Ethan Thomas," Moore said. He said the name like he was tasting something spoiled.

"Yes. He's framing this as a case of reckless endangerment leading to negligent homicide. He claims you convinced a mentally ill girl to stop her medication, leading to her death."

"Is that what he claims?"

"That's what the evidence says, Father. We need to counter that narrative. We need to offer a plea bargain. Involuntary manslaughter. Five years, out in two with good behavior."

Moore laughed. It was a dry, hacking sound.

"A plea bargain?"

"It's the smart move. The jury isn't going to understand exorcisms. They're going to see a dead girl and a priest."

"I don't care what the jury understands," Moore said, leaning forward. The chains rattled loud in the small room. "I don't care about jail. I don't care about my reputation."

Erin put her pen down. "Then what do you care about?"

Moore's eyes locked onto hers. For a second, Erin felt a chill go through her, as if a window had been left open in winter.

"I care about the truth," Moore whispered. "I care about telling Emily's story."

"The truth won't keep you out of prison."

"The truth is the only thing that matters! Emily didn't die in vain. Her suffering had a purpose. People need to know that... that *these things* are real. That the war is real."

"The war?"

"The war for your soul, Ms. Bruner. And mine. And everyone else's."

Erin sat back, crossing her arms. "Okay. You want to tell the story. Fine. But if you take the stand, Thomas will destroy you. He will paint you as a fanatic. A lunatic."

"Let him try."

"He won't just try. He will succeed. Unless you let me guide you. Unless you let me translate your 'war' into something a jury can swallow."

Moore studied her. "You don't believe, do you?"

"I believe in the law."

"That's a pity," Moore said softly. "Because where we're going... the law won't help you."

CHAPTER 8: THE GIRL FROM THE NORTH COUNTRY

Flashback. September 1976.

The Rose farm was a patchwork of green and brown quilt laid over the rolling hills of the Midwest. It was a place of silence, of wind in the cornstalks, of hard work and Sunday mass.

Emily Rose stood on the porch, her suitcase at her feet.

She was nineteen. She had hair the color of wheat and eyes that were wide and eager. She was beautiful in a way that had nothing to do with makeup and everything to do with kindness.

"You have your coat?" her mother asked, wringing her hands in her apron.

"Yes, Mama."

"And your rosary?"

"In my pocket."

"You call us every Sunday. You hear?"

"I will."

Emily looked out at the fields. This was her world. She had never been more than fifty miles from this porch. Now she was going to the University. The city.

It felt huge. Exciting. Terrifying.

She hugged her father. He smelled of diesel and earth.

"Be good, Em," he grunted, hiding his tears. "Make us proud."

"I will, Daddy."

She got into the car, a battered Ford station wagon.

As they drove down the long dirt driveway, she looked back. The house looked small against the vast, grey sky.

A crow sat on the fence post, watching her go.

It cawed. A harsh, grating sound.

Emily shivered.

"Cold?" her mother asked.

"Just... excited," Emily lied.

But it wasn't excitement.

It was a feeling she couldn't name. A feeling of being... marked.

As if she wasn't leaving the farm, but being *sent*.

Towards something waiting in the dark.

CHAPTER 9: THE DORMITORY

The University was a city of brick and ivy. To Emily, it was a wonderland.

She had a roommate, a girl named Alice who listened to disco and smoked cigarettes out the window. She had classes on philosophy and literature. She had a scholarship to keep.

It was perfect.

For the first month.

It started in November. The leaves were turning brown, rotting on the sidewalks.

Emily was studying in the library. It was late. The stacks were empty.

She felt a cold draft.

She looked up. The window was closed.

She went back to her book. *Critique of Pure Reason.* Kant.

Scritch.

A sound from the next aisle.

Like a fingernail dragging across a book spine.

"Hello?" Emily called out.

Silence.

She stood up, walking to the end of the row.

Empty.

Just rows and rows of books.

But the smell...

It smelled like something dead. Like a mouse that had died in the wall and bloated in the heat.

Emily wrinkled her nose. "Gross."

She packed her bag. She felt a sudden, irrational need to leave. To be around people.

She walked quickly back to her dorm. The wind whipped her hair across her face.

She got to her room. 3B.

She unlocked the door.

"Alice?"

The room was empty. Alice was out at a party.

Emily locked the door behind her. She turned on all the lights. The overhead. The desk lamp. The vanity.

She put on some music. The Carpenters. Something soft. Safe.

She changed into her nightgown. She brushed her teeth.

She was safe. It was just an old library. Just a smell.

She climbed into bed, pulling the duvet up.

She closed her eyes.

Click.

The music stopped.

Emily opened her eyes.

The tape deck was off.

Click.

The desk lamp went out.

Click.

The vanity light died.

Only the overhead light remained, buzzing like an angry insect.

Emily sat up, her heart hammering against her ribs.

"Alice? Is that you?"

No answer.

The air in the room grew heavy. Dense. Like the pressure before a thunderstorm.

Emily looked at the door.

The lock was turning.

From the inside.

Slowly. Deliberately.

Click.

Unlocked.

The door creaked open an inch.

Darkness spilled in from the hallway. Not empty darkness.

Living darkness.

And from the crack in the door, a whisper.

"Emily..."

It wasn't a human voice. It sounded like wind blowing through dry bones.

"We've been waiting for you."

CHAPTER 10: 3:00 AM

The city at 3:00 AM was not asleep; it was simply holding its breath.

Erin Bruner lay in her bed, the sheets tangled around her legs. She was awake. She had been awake since 2:59.

She stared at the digital clock. The red numbers burned in the darkness.

3:00.

It stayed 3:00 for a long time. Too long.

Erin blinked. The colon between the numbers wasn't blinking. Time had stopped.

She sat up. The air in her bedroom was cold. Not the cool of air conditioning, but the deep, bone-aching chill of a meat locker.

She reached for her water glass. Her hand shook.

Stop it, she told herself. *You're a partner at a major law firm. You don't get scared of the dark.*

But she was scared.

Because the smell was back.

Sulfur.

And something else. Something sweet. Rotting flowers.

Scritch.

It came from the living room.

Erin grabbed the heavy brass lamp from her nightstand. She didn't have a gun. She didn't believe in them. Right now, she regretted that political stance.

She walked into the hallway. The floorboards, usually creaky, were silent. As if the wood itself was afraid to make a sound.

The living room was bathed in the orange glow of the streetlights.

Jasper, her cat, was standing on the back of the sofa.

He was hissing.

His back was arched so high it looked like his spine might snap. His tail was a bottle brush of fear.

He wasn't looking at the door. He wasn't looking at the window.

He was looking at the empty armchair in the corner.

The leather chair Erin's father had given her.

Erin looked at the chair.

It was empty.

But the leather... the seat cushion was depressed.

Deeply depressed.

As if a heavy weight was sitting there.

Erin froze. Her breath caught in her throat.

"Who's there?" she whispered.

The depression in the leather shifted.

The leather creaked. *Eeeeeee.*

The sound of someone shifting their weight. Leaning forward.

Erin backed away. "I'm calling the police."

The depression began to rise.

Slowly.

As if the invisible occupant was standing up.

Erin didn't wait. She turned and ran back to her bedroom, slamming the door and locking it. She dragged the dresser in front of the door.

She sat on the bed, clutching the lamp, staring at the handle.

3:01.

The clock blinked. Time started again.

But the smell of rotting flowers lingered until dawn.

CHAPTER 11: THE PROSECUTION

Ethan Thomas did not sleep in on Sundays. He was up at 6:00, kneeling by his bed.

"Lord," he prayed, his large hands clasped together. "Grant me the sword of truth. Let me cut through the lies of the Enemy."

Ethan believed in the Enemy. He didn't see the Devil as a metaphor, or a psychological archetype. He saw him as a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour.

And right now, the lion was hiding behind a collar.

He stood up, dressing in his Sunday best. A dark blue suit. Conservative. Solid. Like his faith.

He drove to the First Methodist Church on 4th Street. He sat in the front pew.

During the sermon, the pastor spoke about forgiveness.

Ethan frowned.

Forgiveness was for the repentant.

Richard Moore was not repentant. He was proud. He was dangerous.

After the service, Ethan walked to the DA's office. It was empty on a Sunday.

He went to his desk and opened the file.

The People vs. Richard Moore.

He looked at the autopsy photos of Emily Rose.

He felt a surge of righteous anger.

This wasn't just negligence. This was ritual sacrifice.

He picked up his pen.

He began to write his opening statement.

"We are not here to judge a man's faith," he wrote. "We are here to judge his actions."

He crossed it out.

"We are here," he wrote, pressing the pen so hard it tore the paper, "to name the darkness."

CHAPTER 12: THE STRATEGY

"We need a narrative," Karl said.

The war room at the firm was littered with coffee cups and takeout boxes. It was Monday morning. The trial started in two days.

Erin stood at the whiteboard. She had written two words:

Possession vs. *Psychosis*.

"Thomas is going to go hard on the science," Erin said. "He has Dr. Vogel. He has the autopsy. He has the weight—68 pounds. He's going to say Moore starved her."

"So we attack the science," Karl said.

"We can't," Erin said. "The science is solid. She *did* starve. She *did* have epilepsy."

"Then what's the play?"

Erin uncapped a red marker. She drew a circle around *Possession*.

"We don't attack the science," she said. "We expand the context."

"Meaning?"

"We argue that science is incomplete. We put the supernatural on trial. But not as 'magic'. As an alternative diagnosis."

Karl frowned. "You want to argue that demons are a medical condition?"

"I want to argue that *Emily believed* they were. And because she believed it, the medical treatment wasn't working. In fact, it was making her worse. Moore didn't stop the treatment because he was a fanatic. He stopped it because it was killing her."

"It's risky," Karl said. "You're asking a jury to validate a hallucination."

"I'm asking them to validate *her* reality," Erin said. "If the jury believes that *Moore believed* he was saving her soul... that's not homicide. That's a mistake. A tragedy. But not a crime."

Karl nodded slowly. "Reasonable doubt."

"Exactly. We don't have to prove God exists. We just have to prove that the State can't prove He doesn't."

CHAPTER 13: THE RAIN

The storm arrived on Tuesday.

It didn't start as a drizzle. It started as a deluge. A wall of water that slammed into the city, turning the streets into rivers of oil and trash.

Erin watched it from her office window.

The sky was a bruised purple. Lightning forked down, hitting the radio tower on top of the courthouse.

Crack-BOOM.

The building shook.

She felt it then. The same feeling she had in the car. The pressure.

It was as if the city itself was under siege.

The phone rang.

It was Moore. calling from the jail.

"Ms. Bruner," he said. His voice was calm. Too calm.

"Father? Everything okay?"

"The rain," he said. "Do you see it?"

"I see it. It's quite a storm."

"It's not a storm," Moore said. "It's an arrival."

Erin felt a chill on her neck.

"What do you mean?"

"They know the trial is starting. They're gathering, Erin. The Prince of the Air. He's coming to watch."

The line crackled with static. A harsh, hissing sound.

"...watch... you..."

"Father?" Erin asked. "Was that you?"

Silence.

Then the line went dead.

Erin hung up the phone.

She looked back at the window.

The rain lashed against the glass, sounding like a thousand fingernails tapping for entry.

Scritch. Scritch. Scritch.

She grabbed her briefcase.

She walked out of the office, turning off the lights.

But even in the dark, she could feel eyes on her back.

The trial had begun.

And the defendant wasn't the only one on trial.